



SRI LANKA: Discover the Pearl of the Indian Ocean

ITINERARY

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Day 5: Kandy
Day 6: Kandy
Day 7: Hatton
Day 8: Hatton
Day 9: Yala
Day 10: Yala
Day 11: Welligama
Day 12: Welligama
Day 13: Departure from Negombo

DETAILED ITINERARY**Day 01: Airport (BIA) → Negombo**

Welcome to Sri Lanka.

Upon arrival, by special arrangement, you'll be met as you exit the plane by our representative, who will be holding a sign with your name on it. The representative will then expedite you through Immigration formalities, and escort you to the comfortable Silk Route Lounge where your Private National Guide will be waiting for you. Relax and have a refreshing drink and snacks while your bags are collected for you. If you would like to have some local currency with you during your stay in Sri Lanka, the airport would be the ideal place to exchange currencies, as there are several exchange counters with competitive rates, as well as ATMs that accept Visa and MasterCard.

Once your luggage is delivered to the lounge, porters will accompany you through a special VIP track to your private vehicle and take an easy 25 minutes' drive to Negombo and check in at the hotel

Meals: None

Day 02: Negombo → Sigiriya

Following the breakfast, check out and depart on a 3-hour scenic drive to Sigiriya and check in at the hotel for lunch (at your own expense) followed by some downtime.

Later this afternoon at 04:00 PM, head out to conquer the Sigiriya Rock Fortress, a UNESCO World Heritage Site built by King Kashyapa (477-495). The "Lion Rock" is a citadel of unusual beauty rising 200 meters from the scrub jungle. The rock was the innermost stronghold of the 70-hectare fortified town. A moat, rampart and extensive gardens, including the renowned water gardens, ring the base of the plateau. Not to be missed are the Heavenly Maidens frescos hidden away in a sheltered pocket of the rock, approached by a spiral stairway. The hike to the top and back is many hundreds of steps, moderately strenuous and takes approximately two-three hours depending on your pace.

Please note that to reach the top of Sigiriya Rock, there are nearly 1,200 stone steps up and then down. Anybody in reasonably good condition will be able to venture to the top of Sigiriya Rock

and it's certainly worth the effort, however it's important to know these little details before embarking on this outing. The Sigiriya Rock experience takes approximately 90 minutes to three hours depending on the pace at which you wish to ascend and descend.

Following the visit, return to the hotel for the evening.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner



Day 03: Sigiriya

This morning, you will then proceed to a nearby Buddhist monastery and participate in a traditional almsgiving ceremony for resident monks. Almsgiving has been a sacred tradition that has been a part and parcel of Sri Lankan culture from time immemorial. Monks only have two meals a day. One in the morning and the last one before 12 noon. Thereafter they engage in their spirituality and meditation and only have some fruits during dinner time. Therefore, presenting the monks with their last main meal for the day is considered as an act of merit.

Return to the hotel afterwards and enjoy the rest of the day at leisure. Later this evening, visit Jetwing Vil Uyana by 06:30 PM to enjoy an hour-long nocturnal wildlife experience with the resort naturalist to spot the elusive Grey Slender Loris, a nocturnal primate, hidden in the scrublands around the hotel. Known for its protruding eyes and nimble limbs, the loris scavenges for insects and berries above the trees on the trail that has been carefully designed to allow one to observe the rare creature in its natural habitat.

Meals: Breakfast, Dinner

Day 04: Sigiriya → Polonnaruwa → Minneriya → Sigiriya

After breakfast this morning, depart on a 90-minute drive and explore the medieval capital of the island, Polonnaruwa. Polonnaruwa was the second capital of Sri Lanka ruled by King Vijayabahu after the destruction of Anuradhapura in 993. Apart from the Brahmanic monuments built by the Cholas, the site comprises monumental ruins of the fabulous 'garden city' created by Parakramabahu I in the 12th century. The visit is of four parts, paying homage to the strategic planning of this archaeological city by its first rulers. We start off with the King's Palace which still stands tall giving us an idea of the architectural superiority which existed during ancient times. After a quick visit to the palace and the baths, we then visit the Tooth Relic Temple, the magnificent Image House, and the historical 'Vatadage'. The visit ends at the Gal Vihara Temple where we witness the awe-inspiring Buddha statues carved out of rock. Bicycles are available should you wish to cycle through the archaeological sites.



Following the visit to the archaeological site, settle in at a rural café for an authentic Sri Lankan lunch cooked on clay pots and pans. Indulge in the various aromas and flavours that go into these local dishes. After a delightful lunch, embark on an afternoon game drive in the Minneriya / Kaudulla / Hurulu National Park. The park covers a large area of land, water bodies and consists of a mixed forest of evergreen shrubs, a favourite habitat for animals, which include deer, crocodiles and wild elephants. During the dry season from June to September, this tank attracts herds of elephants to graze and bathe. In more recent times it has been discovered that the park witnesses the largest elephant gathering in the world during these months. You can also see huge flocks of birds, including cormorants and painted storks that come to fish in the shallow waters.

Depending on the day's elephant sightings, your guide will liaise with regional experts and will take you to one of the above-mentioned parks, which are adjoining each other and allow the

Elephants to roam freely across them. After an exhilarating game drive, return to the hotel for the evening.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 05: Sigiriya → Dambulla → Matale → Kandy

Check out after breakfast and begin your journey towards Kandy; the last bastion of Buddhist political power against colonial invasion. This hill station is remarkable for the natural beauty of its setting in a peaceful wooded valley overlooking a vast artificial lake. The palace, shrines and British period buildings give it a special character, while Buddha's Tooth Relic lends a religious importance to the historic highland capital. (approx. 2.5 hours).

Enroute, stop by the UNESCO World Heritage Site – Dambulla Cave Temple, known for its richly painted cave temples. Dambulla is a vast isolated rock mass, and it was here that King Valagamba took refuge from invasions in the 1st century BC, later turning the caves into a rock temple. Some of its frescoes are over 2,000 years old. Another highlight is a colossal figure of the recumbent Buddha carved out of the living rock, some 15 meters long. The caves have a mixture of religious and secular paintings and sculptures with ceiling frescoes depicting scenes from Buddha's life and Sinhalese history.

You will then drive to Matale and visit a Private Spice Garden. Here, you will learn about fragrant clove, cinnamon, cardamom, nutmeg, mace and pepper, and many other favourites such as cocoa and vanilla. Your guide will explain the different spices and show how some of these spices are grown, processed and practically applied for cooking and medicinal purposes. After a tour of the garden, take part in a hands-on cooking demonstration followed by a delicious authentic Sri Lankan lunch, enriched with local spices.



Arrive in Kandy afterwards and visit the sacred Temple of the sacred Tooth Relic, also known as the “Dalada Maligawa” in Kandy is one of the most venerated places of worship for Buddhists, during the evening pooja time for a private viewing. Built in the 16th century, this temple houses the sacred Tooth Relic of the Buddha brought to Sri Lanka during the reign of King Meghavarna (301-328). The relic is encased in seven caskets, one kept inside the other, the outermost of which has a shape of a stupa, adorned with a large number of gold ornaments. Several buildings have been added to the temple complex by successive rulers, the latest being the Golden Canopy over the inner shrine where the Tooth Relic is placed. Originally the Temple was within the King’s palace complex as it was the symbol of Royal Authority.

Following the visit to the temple, check in at the hotel for the evening.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 06: Kandy

Following an early breakfast, visit Chandani, a local artist in the area, in her humble home which is accessed by walking through a working Tea Plantation. She is a mother who supports her family with her creative gift of artistry. She is involved in painting on fabrics, Batik art and creating a range of uncommon but innovative handicrafts, using natural resources and day-to-day waste to ensure environmentally friendly products. Here, you can learn about the handicraft and batik trades in Sri Lanka, and how the olden methods of artistry are threatened due to urbanization, free market movements and lifestyles, and what some of them are doing to keep the trade alive and carry forward the traditions.

Next, visit the outskirts of Kandy and meet your host Chami at his humble home nestled in the hills of the Kandy. This young and energetic individual lives in the quieter and hilly side of Kandy with his wife and young daughter. Chami’s wife prepares delicious Sri Lankan meals and you get the unique opportunity to have hands-on cooking experience. It will begin with a visit to a local market, where you will learn how to select the best fresh produce. You will then proceed to the mud hut kitchen and learn how to prepare mouthwatering Sri Lankan dishes. Once the class is complete, you will have the opportunity to taste the prepared food.

After a delightful lunch, visit Master Ruwan, who is a guru of the ancient Kandyan art of dancing and drumming. Traditional Kandyan dances include the cobra dance, mask dance and the Ginisila (showing power over fire). The entire frenetic and colourful spectacle climaxes with an amazing fire-walking act. The dancers wear elaborate costumes including a headdress, their chests only covered by a decorative beaded net. The Kandyan Dance is traditionally performed to percussion only; To assist the dancer to keep rhythm a small pair of cymbals is also used as well as a conch shell to announce the arrival of the dancers and the climax of the dance. This experience is very engaging as our local dancing master will teach you the basics of dancing and drumming if you are interested.

Afterwards, stop by the ‘ancient craft artisans’, engaging in the process of traditional brass making, producing brassware using traditional methods and techniques and whose dedication for arts, sculptures and crafts go back to the ancient Kandyan Kingdom period.

Return to the hotel afterwards.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 07: Kandy → Peradeniya → Hatton

Check out after breakfast this morning and visit the Royal Botanic Gardens with Mr. Bandara Palipana, an expert in Botany. The Peradeniya Royal Botanic Gardens are the largest of the botanical gardens in Sri Lanka and the finest of its kind in Asia. In the Mediterranean climate of Kandy, the gardens are at an elevation of 460-meters above sea-level, tightly bounded on three sides by the loop of the River Mahaweli (Great Sandy River), Sri Lanka's largest river. Before it was decreed a Botanical Garden, it was a pleasure garden in the days of the kings of Kandy. Then during WWII the gardens became the headquarters of the allied command for the pacific.

Proceed to the quaint Peradeniya Railway Station afterwards and board a local train for a 2 hour ride to the tea side town of Hatton. An engineering marvel, this route is spoken of as the most picturesque of rail journeys. The train ascends along winding tracks into the home of the famed Ceylon Tea, with its rolling hills turning into a carpet of velvety green plantations, interspersed with gushing streams and tumbling waterfalls.

11:20 AM → Depart Peradeniya Station

01:30 PM → Arrive in Hatton Station

*First class reserved seats included in the program. On board the train we will arrange light snacks & toiletries. Your luggage will travel by road in your vehicle.



At Hatton, meet your driver for the approximately one-hour transfer to the Ceylon Tea Trails Estate. The estate is perched at an altitude of 4,000 feet in Sri Lanka's panoramic tea region, bordering the World Heritage Central Highlands. This is the ideal setting to unwind and observe life on a working tea estate against the breathtaking backdrop of mountains, lakes, winding roads and waterfalls. The bungalows that now comprise this exclusive resort were some of the first constructed in Ceylon's tea country and named after the Chinese village from which the area's first tea seedlings originated. They were originally built for the British tea estate managers and their families in the days of the Raj. You will have the chance to explore the lush tea fields

and visit a century old factory for a gentle education in the art of Ceylon Tea. There are also many hikes throughout the area.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 08: Hatton

This morning after breakfast, visit a working tea factory with one of Tea Trails' resident planters for a private tour. You will learn about how different types of teas are created. You will be taken through the entire process - from the drying of the green leaf to the process of dehumidifying and provoking the chemical reaction that turns green leaf into tea, to the segmenting of the different particles which result in the different grades, to finally the packing and distribution.

In the early days of the tea industry, before motorized travel came to its assistance, tea planters conducted field inspections across a vast area of tea fields and forest, either on foot or horseback. At midday, they would take a break under the shade of a tree or the shelter of a makeshift hut for lunch and a rest. You will experience this and then some.

Your special "Planters' Lunch" is a plusher, four-course version served in traditional tiffin boxes at a secret location up on the hillside overlooking Castlereagh Reservoir.

Later this afternoon, participate in an exclusive tea tasting session with resident planter, Mr. Bernhard Holsinger, followed by a colonial 'high tea'. This guided experience allows you to taste, learn & appreciate the unique flavour profiles that give different teas their distinction.

Enjoy the remainder of the day at leisure.

At night, enjoy a signature culinary experience unique to Tea Trails, the Tea-infused Dinner, which brings together the subtle influences of the flavours of tea (not to mention the health benefits). Teas grown in various regions of Sri Lanka have distinctly different flavour profiles, and each lends a different effect to types of ingredients and methods of preparation. Earl Grey cured fresh salmon, Moroccan Mint tea crusted lamb cutlet, and Vanilla panna cotta with minted fresh fruits and Hibiscus tea sauce are some examples of a menu that appeals to both the intellectual curiosity as well as the palate of any gourmet.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 09: Hatton → Weerawila → Yala

This morning, bid farewell to your hosts at Tea Trails and along with your guide, take a scenic seaplane ride on a scheduled Cinnamon Air flight to Weerawila, gateway to Yala National Park.

Fly to Weerawila on Cinnamon Air C7 9701, departing 11:15, arriving 12:30 (Economy Class)

Upon landing, meet your driver for the approximately one-hour drive to Yala and to the stylish Wild Coast Tented Lodge. Wild Coast Lodge's unique design, masterminded by a consortium of Dutch, English and Sri Lankan designers, sees the man-made structures blending seamlessly into the surrounding landscape thanks to the use of carefully selected natural materials. The use of fabric and bamboo allows each of the 28 tents to take on the shape and colour of the rocks and boulders that lay scattered nearby, whilst a clever layout in the shape of a leopard's paw alludes to the area's elusive resident.

You'll have a little time to relax and get settled at the resort before your first private wildlife safari with a naturalist guide in the park this afternoon. Yala National Park consists of dry-mixed evergreen forests and shrublands along with open grasslands, water holes, brackish water lagoons and riverine forests. The park's diverse habitat supports large numbers of mammals, such as spotted, barking and mouse deer, sambhar, wild boar, water buffalo and the endangered sloth bear.

This is also one of the best places in the country to see wild elephants and the rare leopard. Large water holes and lagoons support the high density of endangered crocodiles. You can also see large flocks of migratory and resident birds—142 species of birds have been recorded in the park. Of particular note is the rare, black-necked stork, the largest bird in the country.

Return to the hotel as dusk falls and enjoy sundowners on the dunes followed by dinner.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 10: Yala



This morning, you have an early wake-up call at 05:00 AM with coffee/tea and light breakfast at 05:30 AM. Then at dawn depart for another private 4WD Jeep wildlife safari into the national park. Among the many wondrous sites and experiences today, the main goal is to glimpse the magnificent yet elusive leopard.

Return to your resort around 09:00 AM for a full breakfast followed by some leisure time to rest and enjoy the amenities of your resort.

A variety of lectures and workshops are offered through your lodge with focuses ranging from wild elephant behaviour to bird watching and nature walks, which will offer an insight into the fascinating natural surroundings. The resort also offers fascinating excursions to the ancient Buddhist sites in the area. Alternatively, you might like to join another game drive this afternoon, which is an option but will be at an additional cost to be paid directly to the lodge.

This evening, enjoy a private dinner on the dunes!

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Accommodation: Wild Coast Tented Lodge

Day 11: Yala → Weligama

Checkout after breakfast and depart on a 2 hour drive to Weligama and visit Top House; a working cinnamon estate that will provide a unique experience and insight into the industry and history of cinnamon cultivation on the island. The resident owners, a British couple who fell in love with Sri Lanka on a visit, chose to move here permanently, have restored the plantation to its former glory and now produce true Ceylon cinnamon, which grows on the steep slopes of a high hill. The plantation house is perched on the hilltop with spectacular views over the jungle to the north and the Indian Ocean to the south.

The owners have also built an artisan distillery where they extract pure cinnamon leaf oil according to age-old techniques fine-tuned with modern technology. You will take a tour of the estate with the owner, which involves a brief journey by tractor/trailer and covers the nursery, the plantation, the peeling hut and the oil distillery. Here you will learn the history and health benefits of Ceylon cinnamon, and see the harvest, peeling and preparation of quills. There will also be a demonstration on cinnamon leaf bundling and the entire process of cinnamon oil extraction, as well as the surprising uses of this very special essential oil. The tour shows the eco-friendly and perfectly self-sustaining farming process, with every part of the plant used or recycled, and a completely natural and health-giving result. Upon completion of the tour, you will join the owners for a delicious home-cooked lunch at their stunning plantation house, where you can learn more about the life of a cinnamon farmer in Sri Lanka.

Proceed to check in at the Cape Weligama with the remainder of the day at leisure.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 12: Weligama → Galle → Weligama



Early this morning at 06:00 AM, depart on a 10-minute drive to the Mirissa Fisheries Harbour to board your exclusive Catamaran and sail out for a whale and dolphin watching expedition. This experience on the southern coast can be an awe-inspiring adventure and a great opportunity to see some of the world's most magnificent creatures in their natural habitat. Sri Lanka is home to

several species of whales, including the Blue Whale, the largest animal on earth. Other species commonly spotted on whale watching tours include Sperm Whales, Bryde's Whales, and sometimes Killer Whales or Orcas. Dolphins, Flying Fish and Turtles may also be seen during the tour. These majestic creatures can be seen just a few miles off the coast and makes for an unforgettable experience.

Breakfast and lunch will be served on board. As you head back, the catamaran will anchor off the Weligama Bay for you to enjoy a relaxing swim and paddle boarding.

Return to Cape Weligama afterwards for some downtime.

Later this afternoon at 04:00 PM, depart for Galle and meet your resident host and embark on a 90-minute private tour of the Fort. The Galle Fort is a UNESCO World Heritage site originally built by the Portuguese and later extended by the Dutch in 1663. The ancient seaport of Galle was once called Tarshish, from which King Solomon drew ivory, peacocks and other valuables. Certainly, cinnamon was exported from Sri Lanka as early as 1400 BC and the root of the word itself is Hebrew, so Galle may have been a main port for the spice. The "modern" history of Galle starts in 1505, when the first Portuguese ship under Lourenço de Almeida was driven there by a storm. In 1640, the Portuguese had to surrender to the Dutch East India Company. The Dutch built the present Fort in the year 1668. They built a fortified wall using coral & stone, and built three bastions known as "Sun," "Moon" and "Star".

As the walk concludes, hop over to the Galle Fort Hotel for an Arrack Tasting Masterclass a.k.a. their Rope Walk. Arrack is a quintessential Sri Lankan drink with over 100 varieties of the spirit being produced locally. This local favourite is distilled and aged in wooden casks, which adds to its unique flavour profile. Venture through five specialty arracks that will be paired with carefully chosen nibbles known as 'bites' in Sri Lanka. So, delve into the world of arrack one sip at a time!

Following the tasting, enjoy a Feast of Ceylon Dinner at the Galle Fort Hotel!

After dinner, return to Cape Weligama for the evening.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Day 13: Weligama → Bentota → Colombo → Airport (BIA)

After breakfast this morning, depart on a 90-minute drive to Bentota and visit the Lunuganga Estate. Lunuganga is a Sri Lankan Architectural masterpiece. It is the former country residence of the world-renowned Sri Lankan architect, the late Geoffrey Bawa. The garden was once a 25-acre rubber estate bought by Bawa way back in 1948, which he designed the estate into a garden paradise after decades of careful, exquisite, creative thought and design. Lunuganga reflects Bawa's legacy through his dedication to architecture, and personal life's work and is an inspiring place to visit and savour. With astonishing views and beautiful interiors, with many original Bawa artwork and blueprints on the walls, this is a must visit place for architectural enthusiasts. Guests dine at the edge of the tranquil Dedduwa Lake. Today Lunuganga is managed by the Geoffrey Bawa Trust and offers guests a rare opportunity to step inside the private life of one of the world's most celebrated architects - a man dubbed as "the father of Asian architecture".



Following the tour, sit down for a lovely lunch at the gardens. Continue on a 90-minute drive to Colombo afterwards and check in at the Shangri La followed by some downtime. We will have reserved day-use rooms for you to relax and freshen up before your departure later this evening.

This afternoon, enjoy a drive around the capital. Colombo is fascinating, with a cozy mixture of past and present and is the commercial centre of the country. The original trading settlers - the Portuguese, Dutch and British have all left in their wake churches and monuments, names and religions, costumes and food and smatterings of their languages, which have been absorbed into the speech of Sri Lankans. You will be passing by the Town Hall Building, Gangaramaya Temple,

The National Museum for Natural History, Independence Square and a few other notable highlights. At 04:00 PM, embark on a private heritage tour of Colombo with your host, Mark. This exclusive walk begins at the Old Dutch Hospital. Every city has a character that loves it, studies it, and shares their knowledge and passion with those who want to learn about it. Colombo has Mark. His walking tour will take you through the years of the Portuguese and Dutch Fort right at the heart of the city to the most recent British period. Start with a visit to the outer streets of Pettah where your tour will commence. Along the way, you will explore a handful of the many lively streets that sell everything from textiles to electronics to spices. Hidden within these streets you will find yourselves coming up to the Old Dutch Museum where you can feast your eyes on the pristine architecture of the mansion that was built in the latter part of the 17th century and was initially the residence of Count August Carl Van Ranzow.

After Mark drops you off at the Dutch Hospital, step into the world-famous Ministry of Crab for a sumptuous seafood dinner! After dinner, return to the Shangri La to freshen up, before checking out and returning to the Bandaranaike International Airport in time for your international flight home. We will arrange a special VIP departure service for your comfort and convenience.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

Accommodation: Shangrila / Similar (Day use)

ACCOMMODATION



Negombo- The Wallawwa



Sigiriya- Water Garden



Kandy - Kings Pavillion



Hatton- Ceylon Tea trails



Yala - Wild Coast Tented lodge



Weligama- Cape Weligama



Colombo - Shangri La

Inclusions

- Accommodation in Negombo for 1 night
- Accommodation in Sigiriya for 3 nights
- Accommodation in Kandy for 2 nights
- Accommodation in Hatton for 2 nights
- Accommodation in Yala for 2 nights
- Accommodation in Welligama for 2 nights
- Day use room in Colombo
- Airport transfers
- All transfers and sightseeing as on itinerary
- Seaplane transfers
- Meals as per the itinerary
- English speaking local Tour Guide
- Sightseeing admission fee
- All applicable taxes as on date

Exclusions

- International air ticket other than the mentioned
- Expenses of personal nature such as drinks, tip, laundry, phone etc.
- Extra expenses due to nature and unforeseen events.
- Travel Insurance.
- Visa

Notes

- Rooms are subject to availability at the time of booking
